



A QUICK STORY • BEFORE WE BEGIN

For the 47th time this month, I'm copy-pasting my own taste into a chat window.



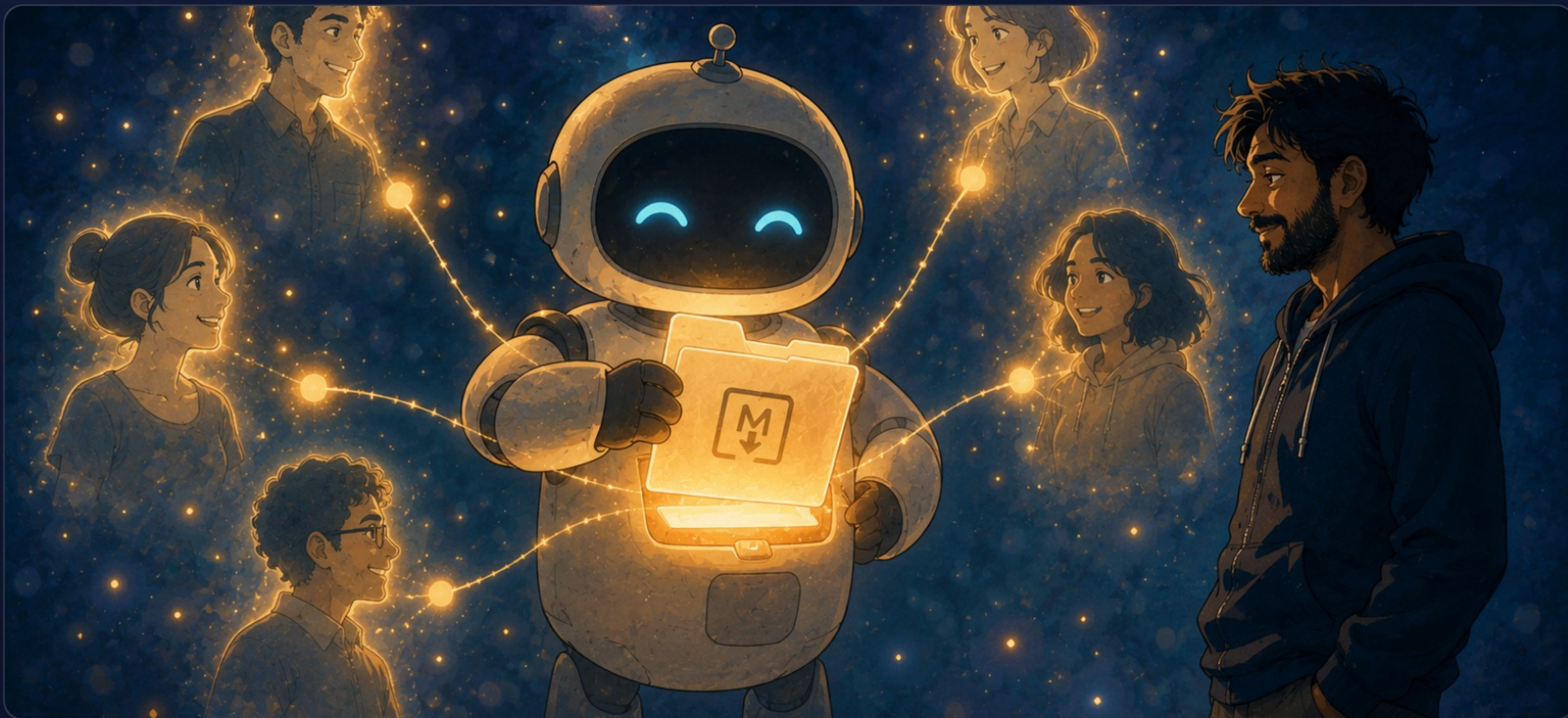
I wasn't being helpful. I was becoming a bottleneck.



My instincts had a home. The home was my laptop.



The minute I logged off, my team's output quality logged off too.



Turns out — they can.

THE PREMISE

The next AI leap isn't a better *model*— it's a better *package* for your taste.

Every team has the person whose AI outputs are just better.
The problem is that "better" lives in their head and disappears the moment they log off.
Agent Skills are how you fix that.

SKILLUP AI

MICROSOFT GARAGE • HYDERABAD

22 MAY 2026

Institutionalize *your instincts.*

Encoding expertise, taste, and tribal knowledge into reusable AI skills.

tezan sahu • applied scientist ii • m365 core idc •

A little *about me.*

- **Microsoft IDC** (2021 – Present)
 - Applied Scientist II** (2025 –) · M365 Copilot Extensibility
 - Software Engineer II (2024 – 25) · M365 Copilot Extensibility
 - Data & Applied Scientist II (2023 – 24) · Bing Autosuggest + Search History
 - Data & Applied Scientist (2021 – 23) · Bing Autosuggest
- **Visiting Faculty** · Bower School of Entrepreneurship
- **IIT Bombay** (2017 – 21) · Major Mech. Engg. **9.90/10**, Minor CSE · Institute Rank 2
- Author · **Beyond Code** (National Bestseller)
- Author · **Low-Pass Filter** — an AI newsletter
- **7** US Patents · **2** Research Papers
- Empowered **20,000+** students & professionals in AI & Data Science



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WHAT WE'LL COVER

The *agenda*.

01 The pain you've been ignoring

Repeated prompts, tribal knowledge, the libraries nobody uses.

02 What a Skill actually is

A folder. A markdown file. Progressive disclosure. That's it.

03 Where they already run

Claude Code, GitHub Copilot, and the M365 Copilot direction.

04 Skills built for *this* room

For engineers, data folks, PMs, finance, HR, consulting.

05 Live build • under 5 minutes

One skill, from blank repo to working tool, on stage.

06 Principles & your challenge

How to write skills that don't suck. What to build this week.

BEFORE WE GET TO THE FIX

Sound *familiar?*

THE REPEATED PASTE

The same 200 words. Every chat.

"Write this in our team's voice. Use our headings. Follow our review checklist. And our handoff format." Copy-pasted. Every. Single. Time.

TRIBAL KNOWLEDGE

Expertise that lives in one head.

Your most senior PM, scientist, or engineer carries nuance the agent never sees — until they're OOF, leave the team, or change orgs.

THE PROMPT GRAVEYARD

Prompt libraries nobody uses.

Built with love. Announced in all-hands. Lived in a Loop page. Forgotten by Friday. (Don't lie. We've all built one.)

THE QUIET BOTTLENECK

"Can you Copilot this for me?"

One person on every team becomes the AI-whisperer. It feels flattering. It is, structurally, a single point of failure.

THE ONE-LINE MINDSET FLIP

Stop writing prompts. Start installing skills.

BEFORE — PROMPT ERA

You carry the expertise.

repeat it in every chat · lives on your
desktop · leaves with you



AFTER — SKILLS ERA

The agent holds it.

install once · loads on demand · ships
with the repo

THE ENTIRE MENTAL MODEL

A skill is a *folder*.

```
my-skill/  
├─ SKILL.md  the brain  
├─ scripts/  optional · executable  
├─ references/ optional · domain docs  
└─ assets/   optional · templates
```

No SDK. No framework. No pipeline.

name	Unique ID. Lowercase-hyphen. (always loaded)
description	The most critical field. When + why to load. Keywords are everything. (always loaded)
body	Step-by-step instructions, checklists, examples. (loaded only on match)
sub-files	Referenced docs & scripts. (loaded only when the sub-task needs them)

WHY SKILLS SCALE AND SYSTEM PROMPTS DON'T

Progressive disclosure.

LEVEL 01 • ALWAYS ON

name + description

~20-50 tokens per skill

Loaded at startup for every installed skill. The agent's internal table of contents.

LEVEL 02 • ON MATCH

full SKILL.md body

loaded when your ask matches

Full instructions flow in only when the agent decides the skill is relevant to *this* turn.

LEVEL 03 • ON DEMAND

sub-files & scripts

loaded inside the skill

Referenced docs & helper scripts loaded only when the skill itself needs them for a sub-task.

*Install 50 skills. Only 1-2 load per task. Context stays **clean**.*

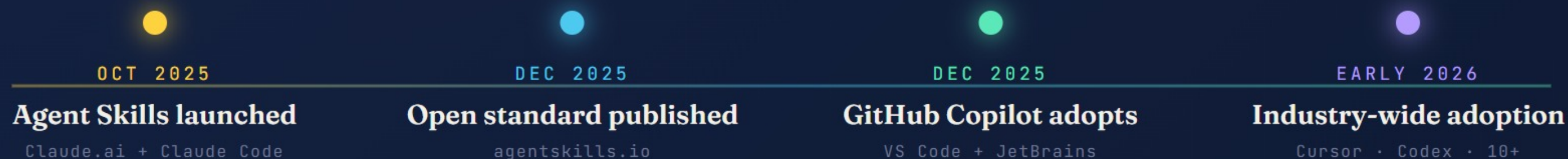
DON'T CONFUSE THESE

Skills vs Agents.

	SKILLS	AGENTS
WHAT IT IS	Packaged expertise for an existing agent.	An autonomous loop: plan → act → observe.
WHO BUILDS IT	Anyone who can write Markdown.	Engineers with frameworks & orchestration.
BUILD TIME	15 – 30 minutes.	Days to weeks.
PORTABILITY	Works across Claude, Copilot, Cursor, Codex...	Tied to the framework you wrote it in.
USE WHEN	You need <i>your way</i> applied consistently.	You need new tools, APIs, or multi-system wiring.

IN 7 MONTHS IT WENT FROM ONE VENDOR TO INDUSTRY-WIDE

A short *origin story*.



*MCP did this for **tools**. Skills are doing it for **expertise**.*

WHERE IT RUNS • 1 OF 3

Skills in *Claude Code*.

JUST DROP THE FOLDER • ZERO CONFIG

```
# personal – every Claude session, every repo  
~/.claude/skills/<skill-name>/
```

```
# project – checked into git, shared with team  
.claude/skills/<skill-name>/
```

- ▶ No API. No upload. No registration.
- ▶ Skills trigger automatically — no slash command.
- ▶ Can also be pushed via the Claude Console for org-wide rollout.

OFFICIAL SKILLS • [GITHUB.COM/ANTHROPICS/SKILLS](https://github.com/anthropics/skills)

PPTX

DOCX

XLSX

PDF

SKILL-CREATOR

WEBAPP-TESTING

MCP-BUILDER

Apache 2.0. Battle-tested. Use as-is or fork.

```
/plugin install document-skills
```


WHERE IT RUNS • 2 OF 3

Skills in *GitHub Copilot*.

Announced Dec 18, 2025. Same open standard. Zero migration from Claude Code skills.

DIRECTORY LOCATIONS

```
.github/skills/<skill-name>/SKILL.md # project
```

```
.claude/skills/<skill-name>/SKILL.md # auto-recognized ★
```

```
~/.copilot/skills/<skill-name>/SKILL.md # personal
```

★ Claude Code skills auto-recognized by Copilot.

SETTINGS • DON'T MISS THESE

- ▶ **VS Code** → Settings → `chat.useAgentSkills` → Enable
- ▶ **VS Code Insiders** → Agent mode → available by default
- ▶ **JetBrains** → Settings → GitHub Copilot → Chat → Agent → Enable Agent Skills (Preview)
- ▶ **Enterprise** → Admin must enable Editor preview features policy *first*.

WHERE IT RUNS • 3 OF 3 • THE MICROSOFT ANGLE

Skills @ *M365 Copilot.*

THE DIRECTION OF TRAVEL

Declarative agents, plugins, and Copilot connectors are converging toward a **packaging model** that looks a lot like skills.

- ▶ Same instinct: separate *WHAT* the agent should do from *HOW* it's wired.
- ▶ Same instinct: portable, declarative, markdown-shaped.
- ▶ Same instinct: install once, used by many.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOU

The muscle you build writing skills today *is* the muscle you'll use to extend M365 Copilot tomorrow.

- ▶ Description-writing → trigger design.
- ▶ Progressive disclosure → context engineering.
- ▶ Sub-files & scripts → tool composition.

*The format you learn here **compounds**.*

WRITE ONCE, RUN EVERYWHERE

The *open standard* ecosystem.

HOSTS

Claude Code

GitHub Copilot

OpenAI Codex

Cursor

VS Code

Windsurf

Amp

Goose

Letta

OpenCode

LAUNCH PARTNERS

Atlassian

Canva

Cloudflare

Figma

Notion

Ramp

Sentry

Stripe

Zapier

[GITHUB.COM/ANTHROPICS/SKILLS](https://github.com/anthropics/skills)

Official Anthropic skills · Apache 2.0.

[GITHUB.COM/GITHUB/AWESOME-COPILOT](https://github.com/github/awesome-copilot)

GitHub community skills, growing fast.

[SKILLS.SH](https://skills.sh)

Discovery hub · 150+ skills across hosts.

MAKE IT REAL • PICK THE COLUMN CLOSEST TO YOU

Skills built for *this* room.

🏢 ENGINEERS

- /code-review** your team's conventions, security checklist, naming rules.
- /pr-description** commits → PR write-up in your team's template.
- /oncall-triage** runbook + log signatures → next 3 actions.
- /repo-onboard** new engineer → ramp-up brief for this repo.

📊 DATA & APPLIED SCIENCE

- /eda-template** the six diagnostics you always run, in order.
- /kusto-build** natural language → KQL on your schema.
- /experiment-design** A/B set-up + sample-size + guardrail metrics.
- /scrape-analysis** eval scrape → metric + RCA summary.

📋 PRODUCT MANAGERS

- /spec-writer** brief → PRD in your team's exact format.
- /feedback-synthesis** raw verbatims → themed insight clusters.
- /competitor-tear-down** public sources → 1-page positioning view.
- /release-notes** git + PRs → release notes in your tone.

💼 FINANCE

- /variance-analysis** actuals vs plan → MBR-ready commentary.
- /mbr-deck** numbers + narrative → MBR slide pack.
- /close-checklist** month-end close · your team's exact steps.
- /forecast-template** 3-driver revenue forecast in your format.

👤 HR & PEOPLE

- /jd-writer** role brief → JD in your employer voice.
- /interview-debrief** interviewer notes → structured panel sync.
- /perf-review-draft** evidence → calibration-ready draft.
- /onboarding-plan** role + level → 30/60/90 plan.

🔴 CONSULTING & STRATEGY

- /stakeholder-synth** interview notes → themed insight memo.
- /mece-outline** topic → MECE-structured slide outline.
- /exec-summary** long doc → 3-sentence exec brief.
- /slide-narrative** data + recommendation → action-titled deck.

Same pattern. Different expertise. Your taste is the moat.

LIVE • UNDER 5 MINUTES

Live build • */weekly-update.*

A skill that turns raw bullets into a **5-sentence Wins / Risks / Asks** update — in your voice. Universal to every role in this room.

WHAT I'LL TYPE • LIVE

*"Create a skill called **weekly-update** that takes raw bullet points about my week and produces a 5-sentence update with sections **Wins / Risks / Asks**, written in a confident but humble Microsoft IC voice. Trigger when I say "weekly update", "Friday note", or paste rough end-of-week bullets."*

```
/plugin install example-skills@anthropic-agent-skills
```

1

Describe the gap

Tell Claude the workflow you repeat. The clearer the trigger, the better the skill.

2

skill-creator scaffolds

Generates **SKILL.md** + folder + any referenced sub-files.

3

Run on a real example

Try it on this week's actual bullets. Ask Claude what was missing.

4

Commit it

Drop into **.claude/skills/** or **.github/skills/**. Whole team gets it.

SIX RULES THAT SEPARATE GOOD SKILLS FROM DEAD ONES

Design *principles*.

01

Description = the hero shot.

The only field read before triggering. Specific + keyword-rich. **Bad:** "helps with reviews." **Good:** "review PRs against our team's checklist — invoke when reviewing pull requests."

02

One skill, one job.

Single-responsibility. A skill that does 5 things does all 5 poorly. Build 5 focused skills instead.

03

Start lean, grow with evidence.

Minimal `SKILL.md` first. Add sub-files only when you watch the agent reach for context that isn't there.

04

Write for the agent.

Numbered steps and checklists beat paragraphs. Ambiguous prose fails reliably. Procedural language wins.

05

Iterate with the agent.

After a run, ask: "what was missing in that skill?"
The self-reflection is shockingly accurate.

06

Test on real work.

3–5 actual examples from your own week before declaring done. Edge cases tell you what you missed.

A NUANCE MOST TEAMS GET WRONG

The *sharing paradox*.

THE PROMPT LIBRARY GHOST 👻

Centralized skill libraries fail the same way prompt libraries did.

Discovery friction. Maintenance cost. Specificity mismatch.
Psychological distance. *Someone else's tool is never quite your tool.*

WHAT SKILLS FIX • AND DON'T

Skills auto-load — that fixes the *technical friction*.

They don't fix the personalization gap. Building a skill for *your* exact workflow takes 15–30 mins and beats any generic shared skill almost every time.

ORG-WIDE • 3–5

Mandatory standards

Accessibility, security, brand voice, compliance.

TEAM-LEVEL • 5–10

Shared workflows

Spec format, handoff standards, review checklists.

PERSONAL • UNLIMITED

Your working style

Personal shortcuts, niche expertise. *This is where the leverage is.*

DON'T JUST NOD • LEAVE HERE AND SHIP ONE

Your *challenge*.

TODAY • STEP 01

Find your one workflow.

The thing you repeat most. The thing you wish the agent already knew.

TODAY • STEP 02

Run skill-creator.

"Help me create a skill that *[workflow]*. Trigger when *[context]*."

THIS WEEK • STEP 03

Test on real work.

3 actual examples from your week.
Ask the agent what's missing.

THIS WEEK • STEP 04

Share & commit.

Send it to one teammate. Commit to [.github/skills/](#). Watch what happens.

You know your domain better than any AI. You just need to write it down in a folder.

THAT'S ALL, FOLKS

Go *institutionalize* your instincts.

Build one this week. Send me what you ship



connect on **LinkedIn**

linkedin.com/in/tezan-sahu



read **Low-Pass Filter**

lowpassfilter.substack.com